

Excelsior & Dunderberg, A Cemetery, And Off To The Boron Federal Prison Camp

When: June 2nd and 3rd, 2012

Where: Sierra Nevada, Virginia Lakes area

Who: Matthew Hengst, Anne Kircher, Jeff Atijera, Laurent Hoffman, Paul Garry, Michael Gardenias

Pictures:

Trip: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157630044220962/>

Prison: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157630044234810/>

GPS Track:

Dunderberg: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/7335284712/in/set-72157630044220962>

Excelsior: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/7335284980/in/set-72157630044220962>

This was intended to be an easy snow climb where pretty much anyone could come along on and get experience. Of course it was planned 6+ months ago when we thought we might still get some significant late season snow.



...yea...so much for that snow climb.

It was nicely timed in that I really needed a recovery weekend. The 96 mile Memorial Day Massacre had left its mark and the three days between that trip and Excelsior and Dunderberg were insufficient for restoring my ability to walk without extreme pain.

So it all worked out.

Anne flew in that afternoon from her temporary residence in Palo Alto and we met the others at 8 pm at a local park and ride.

By 1 am we had passed through Bishop and I was starting to get a little tired. We pulled in to the dirt road at Sherwin Summit, slept for a few hours, and finished up the last hour of the drive in the morning.

Saturday: Excelsior Via Virginia Lakes



We pulled into the campground near the trailhead and received an enthusiastic greeting from Stephanie, Paul, and Mike who had all driven up the night before. Stephanie had been nice enough to drive up particularly early in order to make sure we had a campsite only to find we were the only occupied site in the entire place. Ah well.

After a quick round of hellos we went to the nearby Virginia Lakes trailhead.



There were a few fishermen scattered about and the lake which had some rather non friendly signs about how we weren't allowed to swim due to it being a drinking water source. Awe...



Note the optimistic ice axes.



We strolled up the trail and here and there found small patches of snow but nothing that made me reconsider my decision to wear light boots instead of leathers.





We made the pass and could see all the snow was going to be avoidable.



We left the trail and crossed some easy terrain.



And soon found ourselves on the summit.





There is some snow up high but nothing like last year.

We hung out on the peak for a while before heading down.





Anne and I let the others go ahead as I was limping due to my blisters and she due to her knees. We took our time and enjoyed the view before descending.





We returned to the campground to find the others had headed off to a local restaurant for dinner. They returned just in time to witness Anne and I's attempt at cooking a pizza dinner.



It wasn't our best attempt but I blame lack of our complete cook set. Still, our camp pizza was edible if slightly burned.



We had a good long time around a campfire that stubbornly refused to do anything but smolder before heading to bed sometime around 10.

Sunday: Dunderberg

With the weather so mild Anne and I had just thrown out a sleeping bag.



This is Anne's "I'm not getting out of the sleeping bag unless there's coffee" look.



Coffee was soon provided.

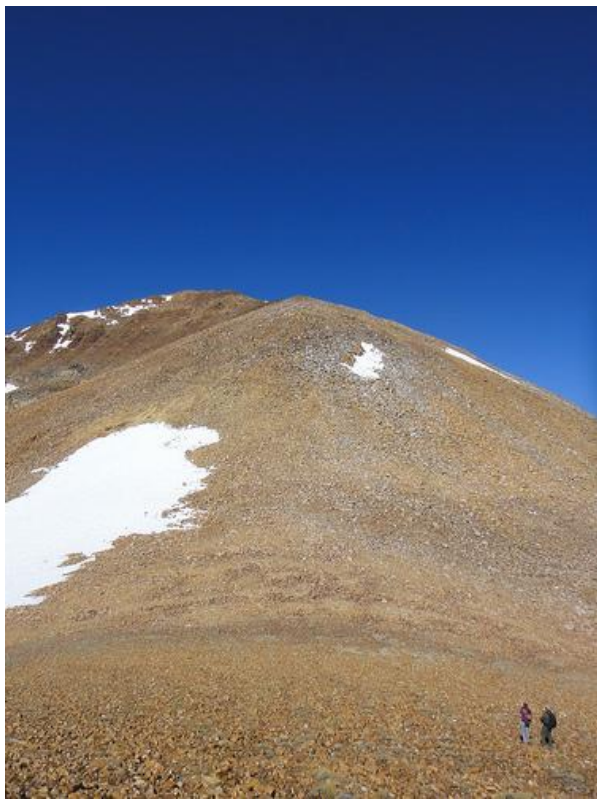


We drove a short distance to Dunderberg Meadow Road where we camped and set off for the peak.



It wasn't a long hike but we had a few thousand feet of gain. It quickly became apparent this peak was a much better snow climb than scree slog.



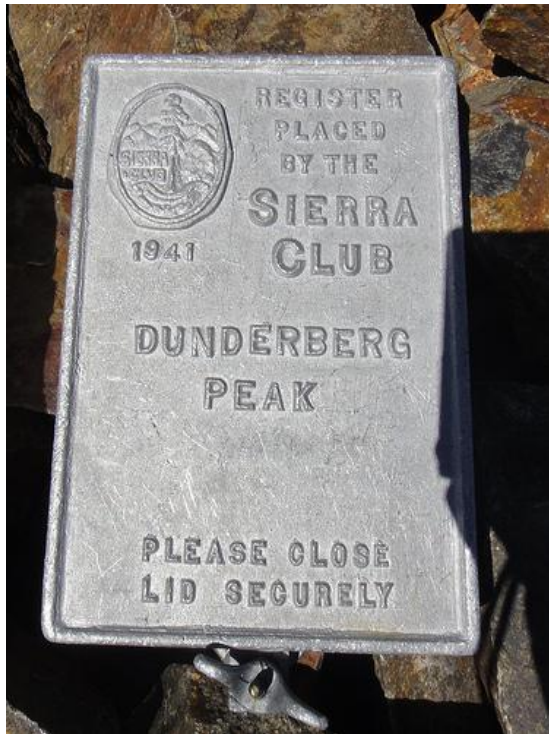




Eventually we reached the somewhat non descript summit.



At least the views from the top were nice. Though that's kind of like saying "You should totally go out with my sister. She's got...great personality..."



There was another of the increasingly rare old school Sierra Club register boxes up top.



Our summit shot.



We had a long sit up top but eventually it was time to head down.



We actually did manage to find one decent bit of snow on the way.



Sadly it wasn't the 2000+ ft patch we needed to glissade happily down to the bottom.



Instead we had a loose crappy scree chute that seemed to go on forever. Yaay...



Eventually it did end though by this time Anne and I were quite a ways behind the others.



We managed to trespass on the Virginia Lake Pack Station on our way back to the car. Not open for business yet.



And then we were done. Depressingly early in the day.

Of course it was a sad sad thing that we were driving home in the daylight so we had to find ways to amuse ourselves.

First, food. We stopped at the Tioga Pass Mobile Mart which has a rather well known deli inside.





Next we headed south and made a quick stop in Big Pine.



(I get a kick out of the sign because it means they must have caught people trying to bury a freshly deceased grandma or two without permission)

Then even further south we knocked another item off the bucket list.



Along the road in a remote part of 395 is an old entrance to...something. I'd driven by it a number of times and always assumed it was a shuttered observatory due to the large white dome on the hill behind it.

Turns out it's the abandoned Boron Federal Prison Camp.



Image from <http://www.radomes.org/museum/recent/BoronAFSCA.html>

From <http://clui.org/ludb/site/boron-air-station-and-prison>



At a remote desert site six miles north of Kramer Junction is a former Federal Prison Camp, which closed in April, 2000. It was one of around 47 minimum security federal prison camps in the country, and housed about 540 male inmates. Workers in the prison assembled parts for military vehicles and rebuilt forklifts for the army. The boarded up prison facility is located on the site of the old Boron Air Station. Also known as the Boron Air Force Radar Facility, it was managed by nearby Edwards Air Force Base, and consisted of several barracks and administration buildings spread out over a few hundred acres, with a large radar dome at the peak of the hill. It was once a part of the National Air Defense Command. Most of the facility was later used by the Prison Camp, and it is now abandoned and being vandalized. It may eventually be sold as surplus property through the GSA. The domed structure at the hill top is still in use by the Air Force and the FAA.

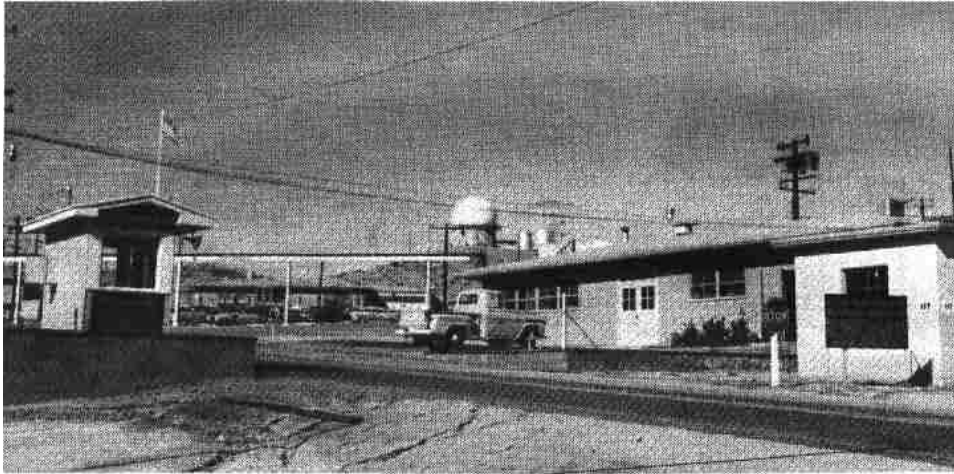
Apparently it was quite the cushy location

http://articles.latimes.com/1986-05-26/news/mn-7699_1_federal-prison

BORON, Calif. – The prison has no walls, fences, bars, gun towers or guns. Guards are nattily attired in gray slacks, powder-blue shirts, maroon ties and navy blazers. Amenities include a swimming pool and two full-time recreation directors.

Some inmates, who are allowed to leave the prison unescorted, spend their days working in nearby communities and their evenings umpiring games for the local Little League.

Incarceration at the Federal Prison Camp at Boron is more a state of mind than a state of siege. An imaginary line around the prison and a few inconspicuous "Off Limits" signs are the only boundaries separating freedom from imprisonment.



MAIN ENTRANCE to Boron AF Station is reached from U.S. 395 at a point approximately 7 miles north of Kramer Junction (Four Corners) where the highway crosses Route 466.
July 25, 1963 issue of the Boron Enterprise -OFFICIAL U.S. AIR FORCE PHOTO-

Picture from <http://www.radomes.org/museum/showsite.php?site=Boron+AFS,+CA>

It's decayed / been trashed a bit since it closed with at least two arson fires taking out different buildings.



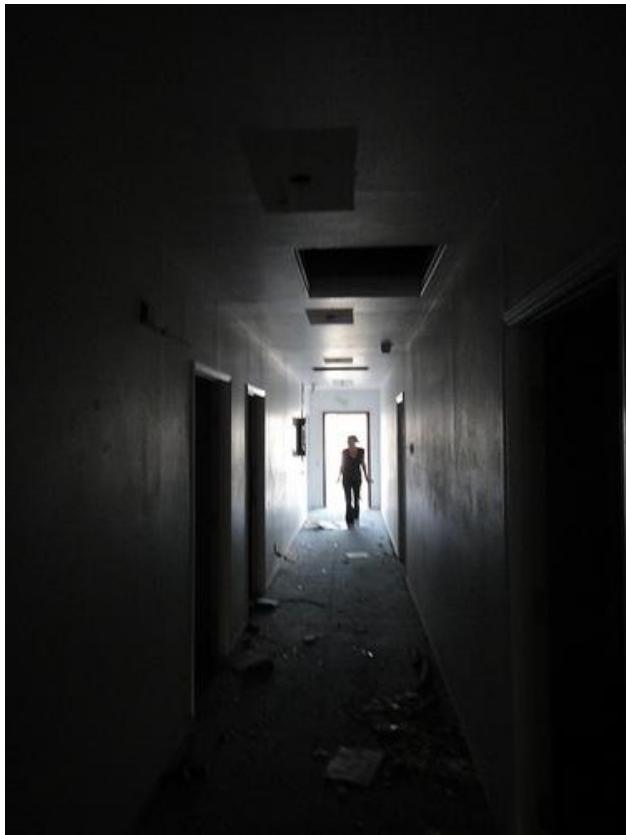
Indeed.



It was about an hour before sunset and we had a strong wind blowing through the ruins causing the buildings to creak rather ominously. Basically the perfect conditions to explore an old abandoned prison 😊

Typical of abandoned structures in the desert every single instance of glass on the property had been smashed, several things had been shot with various firearms, and at least two structures had been set on fire.









The only non trashed structure was the radar installation on top of the hill.



This was protected by a sturdy fence, barbed wire, cameras, and some strongly worded signs forbidding trespassing.



Probably has something to do with this sign...



So we went elsewhere to amuse ourselves.



Apparently we weren't the only ones to think it made the perfect setting for a zombie movie.







There was also a large garage complex where the prisoners apparently fabricated parts for the nearby military base.





There was even an underground area that we couldn't explore fully due to the fact we'd left the headlamps back in the vehicle (damnit!)



Note the singular chair pointed at the far wall... Next time!

Anything loose had been trashed, stolen, set on fire, ect.





The sun was going down and we had a ways more to drive so we reluctantly headed back to where we'd left my vehicle. I was happy to see it was still there.





Just as we were about to leave a singular light came on up the hill attached to the radar dome.



We left and made the drive all the way back home without further detours.

5 days to recover until a rather aggressive snow climb of Darwin and Mendel.